the Empire’.[3]

Look at it from another angle, however, and Akbar was not only asserting imperial authority, but also abiding by the imperial duty of care. It may not be a coincidence that the emperor’s first two rain-related miracles came at the behest of farmers and soldiers. ‘Perhaps the most frequently used pair of terms in Mughal historical literature is “soldiers and peasantry”,’ writes Harbans Mukhia, ‘whose care redeems the state’ – and it may be a legacy of this state that soldiers and peasantry, jawan and kisan, remain a fulcrum of modern Indian political discourse. Indeed, writes Mukhia, in Abul Fazl’s construction of his beloved monarch’s authority, ‘The king’s absolute power . . . gets circumscribed by the responsibility to establish absolute peace among his subjects through the practice of non-discrimination, and to bring about tranquillity and prosperity through paternalistic care’ – to perform, in fact, a miracle more difficult than changing the weather.[4]

Still, one cannot argue that Akbar’s idea of himself as a messiah evolved from a blueprint, nor that it was a well-planned coup against his nobility on behalf of his subjects. There is nothing to suggest that the emperor was merely using the contemporary anticipation of the last Mahdi for his own ends; nothing to suggest that he did not truly believe in the prophecy and in himself – and nothing to suggest that he was an utter lunatic for doing so.

From the wonders that had come, and the spectacles that were to follow, it is tempting to deduce delusions of grandeur at the very least. Few modern readers will imagine Akbar feeding wild deer without also recalling the much-vaunted affinity of contemporary megalomaniacs with their pets. But this was the sixteenth century and ‘it would not do’, writes Moin, ‘to dismiss the emperor’s behavior as pathological’. In this particular time and place, after all, ‘there existed no sharp social distinctions between being absorbed in divinity and being neurotically engrossed in oneself’. Akbar may have nurtured doubt, but only as a way of reaching certainty. On the one hand, he could think about messiahs and divinities with some degree of sardonic distance. In one of his Happy Sayings on the subject, Akbar sounds quite wry: ‘In Hindustan no one has ever set himself up as a prophet. The reason is that pretensions to divinity have superseded it.’[5] On the other hand, the man who sat on a rock all night long, head bent in prayer, wanted to believe; the emperor who rode musth elephants and